

A Trip That Changed My Mind

Vocabulary, Grammar, and Comprehension Handout

Intermediate Level

THE TEXT

People often say that traveling opens your eyes to new worlds and gives you fresh perspectives. I had always known this to be true, but it was not until my recent trip to Thailand that I truly understood the meaning behind those words.

This was not my first visit to Thailand, but it was by far the most memorable one. I experienced a traditional Thai massage, rode an elephant through lush surroundings, fed playful animals at the zoo, and enjoyed countless hours of shopping. However, the highlight of the entire trip was a single photograph — one in which an elephant wrapped its long trunk around me in what felt like a warm embrace. I had never imagined that I would have the chance to be hugged by an elephant! That unexpected moment is what made the whole journey unforgettable.

Before this trip, I had never seriously considered revisiting Thailand. Now, I find myself eager to return before the end of this year. I hope this wish will come true someday — because some destinations deserve more than one visit.

PART A: VOCABULARY (15 Words)

Study the following vocabulary words from the text. Pay attention to how each word is used in context.

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	perspective (n.)	a particular way of thinking about something; a point of view. "Traveling opens your eyes to new worlds and gives you fresh perspectives."
2	memorable (adj.)	worth remembering; unforgettable. "This was by far the most memorable one."
3	traditional (adj.)	following customs or beliefs that have existed for a long time. "I experienced a traditional Thai massage."
4	lush (adj.)	growing thickly and healthily; rich and abundant. "Rode an elephant through lush surroundings."
5	countless (adj.)	too many to be counted; very many. "Enjoyed countless hours of shopping."
6	highlight (n.)	the best or most exciting part of something. "The highlight of the entire trip was a single photograph."
7	trunk (n.)	the long nose of an elephant, used for grasping and breathing. "An elephant wrapped its long trunk around me."
8	embrace (n.)	an act of holding someone closely in one's arms; a hug. "What felt like a warm embrace."
9	imagine (v.)	to form a mental picture of something; to think something is possible. "I had never imagined that I would have the chance."
10	unexpected (adj.)	not expected or predicted; surprising. "That unexpected moment is what made the journey unforgettable."
11	unforgettable (adj.)	impossible to forget; extremely memorable. "That unexpected moment is what made the whole journey unforgettable."
12	seriously (adv.)	in a thoughtful and sincere way; genuinely. "I had never seriously considered revisiting Thailand."
13	consider (v.)	to think carefully about something before making a decision. "I had never seriously considered revisiting Thailand."
14	eager (adj.)	strongly wanting to do or have something; enthusiastic. "I find myself eager to return."
15	destination (n.)	a place to which someone is going or being sent. "Some destinations deserve more than one visit."

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. Traveling to different countries can give you a new _____ on life.
 - a) trunk
 - b) perspective
 - c) highlight
 - d) embrace
2. The sunset over the ocean was truly _____; I will never forget it.
 - a) lush
 - b) traditional
 - c) unforgettable
 - d) eager
3. The _____ of the wedding was the couple's first dance.
 - a) destination
 - b) trunk
 - c) perspective
 - d) highlight
4. She is _____ to start her new job next week.
 - a) countless
 - b) eager
 - c) unexpected
 - d) traditional
5. They spent _____ hours exploring the ancient city.
 - a) traditional
 - b) lush
 - c) countless
 - d) memorable
6. The tropical island was surrounded by _____ green forests.
 - a) unexpected
 - b) eager
 - c) lush
 - d) serious

7. Have you _____ which university you want to attend?
- a) embraced
 - b) imagined
 - c) highlighted
 - d) considered
8. The baby elephant picked up food with its long _____.
- a) embrace
 - b) destination
 - c) trunk
 - d) perspective
9. The _____ rainfall in the middle of summer surprised everyone.
- a) countless
 - b) unexpected
 - c) traditional
 - d) lush
10. Kyoto is a popular _____ for tourists visiting Japan.
- a) perspective
 - b) embrace
 - c) highlight
 - d) destination

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

memorable traditional embrace seriously imagine

1. She had never _____ that she would win first prize in the competition.
2. The hotel room was so beautiful that it made the whole vacation more _____.
3. In many Asian cultures, bowing is a _____ way of greeting people.
4. You should take this opportunity _____; it may not come again.
5. The mother held her child in a tight _____ after the long separation.

perspective eager destination unforgettable highlight

6. After living abroad, she gained a completely different _____ on her home country.

7. The children were _____ to open their Christmas presents.

8. Paris is often considered the top tourist _____ in Europe.

9. Meeting the president was an absolutely _____ experience.

10. The _____ of the conference was the keynote speech by the famous scientist.

PART B: GRAMMAR (5 Patterns)

Study the following grammar structures from the text.

Pattern 1: "It was not until... that..."

Form: It was not until + event/time + that + subject + verb

Use: To emphasize that something happened only after a specific event or moment.

Example from text: *"It was not until my recent trip to Thailand that I truly understood the meaning behind those words."*

More examples:

- It was not until I lost my job that I realized the importance of saving money.
- It was not until she moved abroad that she appreciated her hometown.
- It was not until the exam results came out that he understood how unprepared he was.

Pattern 2: "by far + superlative"

Form: Subject + verb + by far + the + superlative adjective + noun

Use: To emphasize that something is much more than all others in a comparison.

Example from text: *"This was by far the most memorable one."*

More examples:

- This is by far the best restaurant in the city.
- That was by far the hardest exam I have ever taken.
- She is by far the most talented singer in the competition.

Pattern 3: "what felt like + noun"

Form: in/with + what felt like + (a/an) + noun

Use: To describe an experience by comparing it to something familiar, when you are not completely sure of the exact nature.

Example from text: *"An elephant wrapped its long trunk around me in what felt like a warm embrace."*

More examples:

- The seconds before the announcement passed in what felt like hours.

- She spoke with what felt like genuine concern for my well-being.
- The cold wind hit my face with what felt like tiny needles.

Pattern 4: "I had never imagined that... would..."

Form: Subject + had never imagined (that) + subject + would + base verb

Use: To express surprise about something that seemed impossible or unlikely before it happened.

Example from text: *"I had never imagined that I would have the chance to be hugged by an elephant!"*

More examples:

- I had never imagined that I would live in a foreign country.
- She had never imagined that her small business would become so successful.
- They had never imagined that they would meet their childhood hero.

Pattern 5: "find myself + gerund/adjective"

Form: Subject + find(s)/found + myself/himself/herself/themselves + gerund or adjective

Use: To describe a feeling or situation that you didn't plan or expect to be in.

Example from text: *"I find myself eager to return before the end of this year."*

More examples:

- After the trip, I found myself missing the local food.
- She finds herself thinking about him more and more often.
- He found himself unable to stop laughing during the movie.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. It was not until she read the letter _____ she understood his feelings.
 - a) when
 - b) that
 - c) which
 - d) where

2. This is _____ the most beautiful beach I have ever visited.
- a) so far
 - b) very much
 - c) by far
 - d) too much
3. The old house creaked in _____ a human voice.
- a) what sounds like
 - b) what felt like
 - c) what it felt
 - d) what feels
4. I had never imagined that I _____ become a published author.
- a) will
 - b) can
 - c) would
 - d) may
5. After retirement, he found _____ volunteering at the local hospital.
- a) him
 - b) he
 - c) his
 - d) himself
6. It was not _____ midnight that the rain finally stopped.
- a) after
 - b) when
 - c) until
 - d) since
7. Mount Everest is by far the _____ mountain in the world.
- a) higher
 - b) highest
 - c) most high
 - d) more high
8. She had never imagined _____ winning would feel so emotional.
- a) what
 - b) that
 - c) which

d) how

9. The warm blanket wrapped around me in what felt like a gentle _____.

a) hug

b) hugging

c) hugged

d) to hug

10. After moving to Tokyo, Maria found herself _____ Japanese food every day.

a) crave

b) craved

c) to crave

d) craving

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern indicated in parentheses.

It was not until... that...

1. I didn't appreciate my health until I got seriously ill. (It was not until...)

· _____

2. She didn't learn to cook until she moved out of her parents' house. (It was not until...)

· _____

by far + superlative

3. This movie is much better than any other movie this year. (This movie is by far...)

· _____

4. That was the most difficult decision I have ever made. Nothing else comes close.
(That was by far...)

· _____

what felt like + noun

5. The wait at the hospital seemed like forever. (The wait passed in...)

· _____

6. His words hit me and seemed like a slap in the face. (His words hit me with...)

· _____

had never imagined that... would...

7. I was surprised to get a promotion so quickly. (I had never imagined...)

· _____

8. She didn't expect to enjoy skydiving so much. (She had never imagined...)

· _____

find myself + gerund/adjective

9. He didn't expect it, but he started enjoying classical music. (He found himself...)

· _____

10. Without planning to, I kept thinking about that conversation. (I found myself...)

· _____

PART C: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions based on the text.

Tier 1: Literal Understanding

1. According to the text, what did the author already know about traveling?
2. What activities did the author do during the trip to Thailand?
3. What was the author's favorite moment from the trip?

Tier 2: Inference & Analysis

4. Why do you think the author describes the elephant moment as an “embrace” rather than simply saying “the elephant touched me”?
5. What does the phrase “some destinations deserve more than one visit” suggest about how the author's feelings toward Thailand have changed?
6. The author says this was not the first visit to Thailand, but it was the most memorable. What made this trip different from earlier ones?

Tier 3: Critical Thinking

7. The text begins with the idea that traveling gives you “fresh perspectives.” Based on the author's story, do you think this trip actually changed the way the author thinks? Why or why not?
8. Do you think a single moment—like being hugged by an elephant—can truly make an entire trip unforgettable? Or do you think it is the combination of many experiences? Explain your reasoning.

Tier 4: Personal Response

9. Have you ever had an unexpected moment during a trip that completely changed how you felt about the place? Describe what happened.
10. Is there a destination you have visited that you would like to return to? What makes it worth a second visit?

PART D: CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Discuss the following questions with a partner or in small groups. Let the conversation flow naturally from one question to the next.

Theme 1: The Power of Travel

1. Do you agree that traveling can change the way you think? Can you give an example from your own experience?
2. Some people prefer visiting new places, while others prefer returning to a favorite destination. Which do you prefer, and why?
3. What is the most memorable trip you have ever taken? What made it stand out?

Theme 2: Unexpected Experiences

4. Have you ever done something on a trip that you never expected to do—like the author being hugged by an elephant? What was it?
5. Do you think the best travel memories come from planned activities or from unexpected moments? Why?
6. If you could have any unusual experience with an animal during a trip, what would it be and where?

Theme 3: Destinations and Dreams

7. If you could travel anywhere in the world right now, where would you go and what would you do there?
8. The author hopes to visit Thailand again before the end of the year. Do you have any travel wishes for this year?
9. What do you think makes a destination truly worth visiting—the food, the culture, the scenery, or the people? Explain your answer.
10. Some people say that you don't need to travel far to have a meaningful experience. Do you agree? Why or why not?

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) perspective 2. c) unforgettable 3. d) highlight 4. b) eager 5. c) countless
6. c) lush 7. d) considered 8. c) trunk 9. b) unexpected 10. d) destination

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. imagine 2. memorable 3. traditional 4. seriously 5. embrace
6. perspective 7. eager 8. destination 9. unforgettable 10. highlight

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) that 2. c) by far 3. b) what felt like 4. c) would 5. d) himself
6. c) until 7. b) highest 8. b) that 9. a) hug 10. d) craving

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

1. It was not until I got seriously ill that I appreciated my health.
2. It was not until she moved out of her parents' house that she learned to cook.
3. This movie is by far the best movie this year.
4. That was by far the most difficult decision I have ever made.
5. The wait passed in what felt like forever.
6. His words hit me with what felt like a slap in the face.
7. I had never imagined that I would get a promotion so quickly.
8. She had never imagined that she would enjoy skydiving so much.
9. He found himself enjoying classical music.
10. I found myself thinking about that conversation.

Comprehension Questions (Sample Answers)

1. The author already knew that traveling opens your eyes to new worlds and gives you fresh perspectives.
2. The author experienced a traditional Thai massage, rode an elephant, fed animals at the zoo, and enjoyed hours of shopping.
3. The author's favorite moment was when an elephant wrapped its trunk around the author in what felt like a warm embrace.

4. By using the word “embrace,” the author shows that the moment felt personal and emotional, not just physical. It suggests a connection between the author and the elephant, making the experience feel meaningful rather than ordinary.
5. This phrase suggests that the author now values Thailand as a special place. Before the trip, the author had never considered returning, but the experience was so positive that Thailand has become a destination worth revisiting.
6. The unexpected and personal experience with the elephant made this trip stand out. While earlier visits may have included typical tourist activities, this trip had a unique, emotionally powerful moment that the author had never imagined possible.
7. Answers will vary based on personal opinion.
8. Answers will vary based on personal opinion.
9. Answers will vary based on personal experience.
10. Answers will vary based on personal experience.

Conversation Questions

Answers will vary. These questions are designed for open discussion.